

Former Viet Minh members who had remained in South Vietnam often became active Viet Cong organizers as well, operating in small cells for greater security. Tran Van Bo was a typical example. He started off as a propagandist for the Viet Minh before quitting the movement to become a farmer in the Mekong Delta. He rejoined his former comrades some years later after Diem's troops had tried, but failed, to arrest him. Cadres like him formed the nucleus of the National Liberation Front (NLF) when it was founded in 1960.



Weapon of choice

Soviet-manufactured AK-47 rifles—and Chinese variants, such as this Type 56—replaced the carbines with which the Viet Cong were first equipped. The AK-47, often called peasants' rifles, were reliable weapons and produced a tremendous amount of automatic firepower.

Viet Cong recruitment

The movement expanded rapidly. By late 1962, the NLF had around 300,000 active members and one million passive supporters in South Vietnam. The Viet Cong controlled at least a quarter of the villages in the Mekong Delta.

Initially, most new recruits were persuaded to join the Viet Cong voluntarily by the recruiting cadres who regularly visited rural hamlets. One of their arguments was that, once they turned 18, boys would be drafted into the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) anyway. Recruiters assured their recruits that, if they agreed to join the Viet Cong, they could serve close to their homes—in direct contrast to the ARVN policy of posting recruits as far away from their families as possible. There was also the promise of future gain after the war was won and the NLF came to power. Others enlisted to get away from a dull village life. However, as time went on, and recruiting cadres were required to meet provincial targets, compulsion replaced persuasion and young men were pitchforked into joining.